



The Rate Confirmation & Carrier Packet

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 11 of 18 · Getting the Load · about a 14-minute read

You did everything right. You found the load, vetted the broker, negotiated the rate, set the appointments. The broker emails over the rate confirmation. You're slammed, you give it a glance, you sign it and send it back. Except the rate on that document said twenty-nine hundred dollars — and you'd agreed to three thousand. You just signed away one hundred dollars *in writing*. It's not your word against the broker's anymore. It's your signature, against you.

Or picture the other miss: the rate con is perfect, but when you go to get the load released, the broker says they can't — your carrier packet isn't on file. So the load sits while you scramble to dig up insurance certificates and authority paperwork you should've had ready, and a load you fought to win is now at risk because of missing documents.

The handshake on the phone is not the deal — the paperwork is. The deal isn't real until it's in writing, the writing has to be checked, and your credentials have to be ready. This is the last gate before the wheels turn, and it's the one that protects every dollar you negotiated.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Take a rate confirmation, read every line, and verify it matches exactly what you agreed — catching a wrong rate, a missing accessorial, or a bad appointment time *before* you sign, not after. And you'll know what's in a carrier packet and how to have it ready, so a new broker releases your load without delay. In short: you'll turn a verbal deal into a documented, protected one.

1 The Paper Is the Deal

A verbal "we're booked" on the phone gets things moving, but on its own it protects nothing. Two pieces of paper turn that conversation into a real, protected load, and you handle both before any truck moves.

The first is the **rate confirmation** — the written, signed contract for this one specific load. It spells out exactly what was agreed, and it's your proof if anything goes sideways later: a short payment, an argument over the rate, a fight about who owes detention. If it's in writing and signed, you can hold the broker to it. If it's not, you're guessing.

The second is the **carrier packet** — the documents that prove your trucking company is real, authorized, and insured. A broker won't release a load to a carrier they haven't set up, so the packet is the key that unlocks the load. The rate con is *this load's* deal; the packet is your *company's* credentials. Let's take them one at a time.

2 The Rate Confirmation: What It Is, and What's on It

The rate confirmation — you'll hear it called the **rate con**, the confirmation, or just "the con" — is a one-page document the broker sends for every load. Think of it as the contract for that single shipment. Read enough of them and you'll see they all carry the same things: **who's who** (the broker and your carrier, with MC numbers), **the load** (pickup and delivery locations, dates, and the appointment times you set), **the freight** (commodity, weight, equipment), **the money** (the agreed rate, any accessorials spelled out, and the total), **the terms** (payment terms like net-30, plus special instructions), and **reference numbers** (the broker's load or PO number). Here's a typical one — the bright flags mark the three places you check hardest:

RATE CONFIRMATION		Load # SL-44821 net-30
Smith Logistics LLC · MC-123456 · sent before pickup		
WHO'S WHO		
BROKER	Smith Logistics LLC · MC-123456	
CARRIER	Summit Carriers · your MC / DOT	
THE LOAD & FREIGHT		
PICKUP	Atlanta, GA · Tuesday	
DELIVERY	Dallas, TX · Thursday 1:00 PM appointment	VERIFY
EQUIPMENT	Dry van	
FREIGHT	Furniture · ~38,000 lbs	
THE MONEY		
LINEHAUL (RATE)	\$3,000.00	VERIFY
ACCESSORIALS	Detention after ~2 hrs free; lumpers / layover terms	VERIFY
TOTAL	\$3,000.00 all-in	
TERMS	Net-30 · Load # SL-44821	
Sign only the version that's right. Your signature is what makes every number on this page binding.		

RATE CON IS NOT THE BOL

New dispatchers mix these up. The rate con is the *deal* — the contract, sent *before* pickup. The **bill of lading** (the BOL) is signed at the dock *when the freight is loaded*, and it lists the goods themselves; that's part of dispatching the driver, a separate lesson. The rate con is what you agreed to haul it for; the BOL is the receipt for what's in the trailer.

3 Check Every Line Before You Sign

Here is the most important habit in this entire lesson: **never sign a rate confirmation until you've verified it matches what you actually agreed to.** Brokers aren't usually trying to cheat you, but mistakes happen, and a wrong number on a signed rate con becomes *your* problem the moment you sign. So you go down it, line by line:

- 1 **The rate.** Does the number match exactly what you negotiated? This is the single most common place carriers get shorted — a con that quietly reads a little less than the verbal deal. Check it first, every time.
- 2 **The accessories.** Are the things you agreed to actually written in — the detention rate, who pays the lumper, the fuel surcharge? Hard truth: if an accessorial isn't on the rate con, you'll have a very hard time collecting it later. Get it in writing now.
- 3 **Pickup, delivery, dates, and appointment times.** Do they match what you set with the shipper and receiver?
- 4 **Equipment, weight, commodity.** All correct for the truck you're sending?
- 5 **Payment terms.** Net-30, or whatever you agreed?
- 6 **Anything new.** Did the broker slip in a requirement or a penalty you never discussed?

If everything matches, great. If *anything* is wrong, you do not sign. You call the broker, get it corrected, and have them send a **revised rate con**. You only ever sign the version that's right — because your signature is what makes it binding.

4 Sign, Return, and Keep Your Copy

Once the rate con is correct, you **sign it and send it back** — that's the step that locks the booking on paper and tells the broker you're committed. Then do one more thing that pays off later: **keep your copy**. That signed rate con is your reference for the whole load — the times, the rate, the terms, all in one place — and, just as important, it's your proof at payment time. When you go to get paid, the signed rate con plus the proof of delivery are what you invoice against (the getting-paid lesson covers that side in full). Simple principle: an unsigned or un-checked rate con is a loose end; a signed, verified one is a locked, protected deal.

5 The Carrier Packet: Your Credentials with the Broker

Now the other document — and this one isn't per-load, it's per-*broker*. Before a broker will do business with your carrier the first time, they need your carrier packet on file: the paperwork that proves you're a real, legal, insured trucking company. A typical packet includes:

Operating authority

The MC and DOT numbers showing you're a licensed carrier — the same record the broker verifies on the FMCSA site, like you learned in vetting.

Certificate of Insurance COI

Proof your carrier carries the required cargo and liability coverage. Brokers usually want to be named as a *certificate holder* so they're notified if that insurance ever lapses.

W-9

Your tax information, so the broker is able to pay you.

Signed broker-carrier agreement

The master terms between the two companies.

Sometimes: references & payment setup

A voided check — or, if you use a factor, the factoring company's paperwork so the broker pays the factor instead of you.

Usually a one-time setup per broker. Once they've got your packet, you don't resend it for every load — the rate con handles each individual load from then on.

The dispatcher's job here is simple but it matters: have these documents ready, and send them *promptly* when a new broker asks, so the load gets released without the truck sitting. And that factoring note ties straight back to the money lesson — if your carrier factors its invoices, the broker has to know to pay the factor, and that paperwork rides along with the packet.

Walkthrough — Checking the Rate Con, and Sending the Packet

Smith Logistics sends the rate con for the anchor load (Atlanta → Dallas furniture). Go down it line by line against what was agreed.

THE RATE CON ARRIVES — VERIFY LINE BY LINE

RATE	Shows \$2,900 — you agreed \$3,000 . Catch it. ✗
PICKUP	Atlanta, Tuesday. ✓
DELIVERY	Dallas, Thursday 1:00 PM appointment — matches what you set. ✓
FREIGHT	Dry van · ~38,000 lbs · furniture. ✓
ACCESSORIALS	Detention terms listed? — confirm they're written in.
TERMS	Net-30. ✓

Don't sign. Call Smith: "The rate should be \$3,000, not \$2,900." Broker sends a **revised rate con** at \$3,000. Re-check → now correct → **sign & return**. Keep your copy.

THE CARRIER PACKET — SMITH IS A NEW BROKER FOR SUMMIT

Smith won't release the load until Summit is set up. Send the packet: **operating authority (MC/DOT)**, **COI** (name Smith as certificate holder), **W-9**, and the **signed broker-carrier agreement**.

Summit is set up, the load is released. Next loads with Smith: just the rate con.

Notice the catch did the whole job: the rate con came in one hundred dollars light, and because you actually read it instead of signing on autopilot, you caught it and fixed it *before* your signature made it real — the difference between getting paid what you negotiated and eating the loss. Then the packet got the load released. And the appointment time you set earlier was right there on the con — which is exactly why you set it carefully in the first place.

Module 11 Glossary — your quick reference

The two documents that turn a verbal deal into a protected one.

The deal, in writing

Rate confirmation (rate con) The written, signed contract for one specific load — rate, dates, appointment times, accessorials, and terms. Verify it line-by-line before signing; it's your proof if anything is disputed.

Revised rate con A corrected version the broker re-sends when something on the original was wrong. You only ever sign the version that matches what you agreed.

Bill of lading (BOL) Signed at the dock when freight is loaded; lists the goods in the trailer. Different document, different moment from the rate con. (Taught in the dispatching lesson.)

Your company's credentials

Carrier packet The per-broker set of documents that proves your company is real, authorized, and insured — the key that gets a new broker to release your load.

COI (Certificate of Insurance) Proof your carrier carries the required cargo and liability coverage. Brokers are often named as a certificate holder so they're alerted if it lapses.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **What is a rate confirmation, and why does it matter so much?**
2. **The rate con arrives showing a lower rate than you agreed to. What do you do?**
3. **Name three things you check on a rate con before signing.**
4. **How is a rate confirmation different from a bill of lading?**
5. **A new broker won't release your load. What do they most likely need, and what's in it?**

ANSWERS

1. The written, signed contract for one load — it documents exactly what was agreed (rate, dates, times, accessorials, terms) and is your proof and protection if anything is disputed or short-paid.
2. Don't sign — call the broker, get a corrected/revised rate con, and sign only the version that matches. Your signature makes it binding.
3. Any three of: the rate; the accessorials (detention/lumper/fuel-surcharge terms); pickup/delivery dates and appointment times; equipment/weight/commodity; payment terms; and any added requirements.
4. The rate con is the deal/contract the broker sends before pickup; the BOL is signed at pickup and lists the actual freight in the trailer. Different documents, different moments.
5. Your carrier packet — operating authority (MC/DOT), a Certificate of Insurance (COI), a W-9, and a signed broker-carrier agreement (plus factoring paperwork if you factor). Have it ready to send promptly.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 12: DISPATCHING THE DRIVER & THE BOL

And that's the load fully locked down — booked, priced, scheduled, and now in writing, with a signed rate confirmation and your packet on file. The truck is finally cleared to roll. Everything up to this point has been *getting* the load; from here on, you *run* it. Next, you dispatch your driver — you hand him everything he needs to execute that pickup cleanly, including the document he'll get signed the moment the freight is loaded onto the trailer: the bill of lading. The deal is done on paper; now we make the wheels turn.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches rate-con review and the carrier packet as generic skills. Your own operation adds its specifics — its rate-con review checklist and who has signing authority; where it stores the carrier packet (authority, COI, W-9, signed agreements) and who keeps the COI current; its insurance coverage amounts and how brokers are added as certificate holders; its factoring notice-of-assignment process if it factors; and who to escalate to when a broker won't correct a wrong rate con or pushes unacceptable terms. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*